

Child Care Assistance

Quality child care is expensive — but help exists so you can afford it and keep working or studying. Below are the main national starting points. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Even families who think they earn too much often qualify for at least partial help, especially with more than one child. Free local experts (Child Care Resource & Referral) help you find care and assistance you qualify for.

1 Help Paying for Care

Government programs lower or cover your child care costs.

☐ Child Care Financial Assistance (CCDF)

Your state can help pay for child care if you work or attend school. Find your state's program.

→ childcare.gov/consumer-education/get-help-paying-for-child-care

☐ Head Start & Early Head Start

Free, high-quality early education and care for eligible families with kids under 5.

→ www.acf.hhs.gov/ohs/about/head-start

2 Find & Compare Care

Tools to find safe, licensed child care.

☐ Childcare.gov — Find Care

Find and compare licensed providers and learn what quality care looks like.

→ childcare.gov/state-resources

☐ Child Care Resource & Referral (CCR&R)

Free local experts who help you find care and the assistance you qualify for.

→ childcare.gov/state-resources

3 Money Back at Tax Time

Tax credits return some of what you spend on care.

☐ Child & Dependent Care Tax Credit

A credit for child care costs that lets you work. See the Tax Credits guide.

→ www.irs.gov/credits-deductions/individuals/child-and-dependent-care-credit-information

4 More Affordable Options

Other ways to lower the cost of care.

☐ Military Child Care

Fee assistance and programs for military families.

→ www.childcareaware.org/fee-assistancerespite

☐ Pre-K & School Programs

Many states offer free or low-cost pre-K. Ask your school district or CCR&R.

→ **Ask your school district about pre-K**

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Be cautious of unlicensed care and of anyone charging a fee to “apply” for child care assistance — the programs above are free to apply for through official state agencies.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Call your local Child Care Resource & Referral agency first — they know every assistance program and open slot in your area, and the help is free.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national programs. For your state’s child care assistance and local providers, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
